

How to download and install macOS

Use any of these methods to download and install current or previous versions of the Mac operating system on compatible Mac computers. Each macOS includes the latest built-in apps available for that macOS, including Safari, Mail, and Apple Music (formerly iTunes).

[Use Software Update](#) ⌵

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Use Software Update

Software Update is the fastest and easiest way to get macOS updates and upgrades, and it can use less storage space to download and install them. Software Update shows only software that is compatible with your Mac: if it says that your Mac is up to date, then no new software is currently available for your Mac.

[How to update or upgrade macOS using Software Update](#) ›

Use macOS Recovery

If you want to reinstall macOS, or installation using Software Update was unsuccessful, or your [Mac doesn't start up all the way](#) because it doesn't have a working operating system, you can start up from macOS Recovery, then reinstall macOS from there.

[How to reinstall macOS from macOS Recovery](#) ›

Use the App Store

1. Make sure that the Mac you're using to download macOS is [compatible with that macOS](#).
2. If you're downloading macOS in order to [make a bootable installer](#), make sure that your Mac is using macOS Mojave 10.14 or later.
3. Use these links to find macOS in the App Store. If these links don't work as expected, try again using Safari, which is in the Applications folder.
 - Tahoe 26 (use [Software Update](#) or [Terminal](#))
 - [Sequoia 15](#) ↗
 - [Sonoma 14](#) ↗
 - [Ventura 13](#) ↗
 - [Monterey 12](#) ↗
 - [Big Sur 11](#) ↗
 - [Catalina 10.15](#) ↗
 - [Mojave 10.14](#) ↗
 - [High Sierra 10.13](#) ↗
4. Click the Get button in the App Store to begin downloading.
 - If Software Update opens and asks if you want to download macOS, allow the download.
 - If the macOS you're trying to download isn't compatible with your Mac, the App Store might dim the Get button, or you might see a message that the macOS is not compatible with this device, or that the requested version of macOS is not available.

5. After downloading to the Applications folder, the installer opens automatically. Follow the onscreen installation instructions. Or quit without installing to leave the installer in the Applications folder for later use.

Use a web browser for older versions

1. Make sure that the Mac you're using to download macOS is compatible with that macOS. If it isn't compatible, you won't be able to complete these steps.
2. Use these links to download a macOS disk image (.dmg) file. If these links don't work as expected, try again using Safari, which is in the Applications folder.
 - [Sierra 10.12](#) ⬇
 - [El Capitan 10.11](#) ⬇
 - [Yosemite 10.10](#) ⬇
 - [Mountain Lion 10.8](#) ⬇
 - [Lion 10.7](#) ⬇
3. By default, Safari downloads the disk image to your Downloads folder, which you can open from the Dock or by choosing Downloads from Go menu in the Finder. [Learn more about downloading items using Safari.](#)
4. Double-click the .dmg file to open it and see the package (.pkg) file within.
5. Double-click the .pkg file, then follow the onscreen instructions to install the macOS installer into the Applications folder.
6. Open the Applications folder and double-click the macOS installer, named Install [Version Name]. Follow the onscreen installation instructions.

Use Terminal

You can use Terminal to download the installer for compatible macOS versions no earlier than the version that came with your Mac, or the closest version still available.

1. Make sure that your Mac is using macOS Catalina 10.15 or later.
2. Open Terminal, which is in the Utilities folder of the Applications folder. Or use Spotlight  in the menu bar to find and open Terminal.
3. Type the following command in Terminal, replacing <number> with the [latest macOS version number](#) for the compatible macOS that you want to download:

```
softwareupdate --fetch-full-installer --full-installer-version <number>
```

Example: *softwareupdate --fetch-full-installer --full-installer-version 26.1*

Example: *softwareupdate --fetch-full-installer --full-installer-version 15.7.2*

4. Press Return to enter the command. As macOS downloads to the Applications folder, Terminal shows the percentage it's installing (downloading). If Terminal says update not found, that version of macOS is not available for your Mac. You can enter

```
softwareupdate --list-full-installers
```

 to get a list of macOS versions that are currently available for your Mac.

5. When Terminal says that the install finished successfully, the download is complete. Open the Applications folder and double-click the macOS installer, named Install [Version Name], then follow the onscreen installation instructions. Or leave the installer in the Applications folder for later use.

Use a bootable installer

A bootable installer can be useful when you want to install macOS on multiple computers without downloading the installer each time, or when you can't install using macOS Recovery or the other methods.

To download an installer suitable for creating a bootable installer, follow the steps in this article to use the App Store, a web browser, or Terminal to download from a compatible Mac.

[How to create a bootable installer for macOS >](#)

Check macOS compatibility

Find out which computers are compatible with the most recent versions of macOS:

- [macOS Tahoe 26 is compatible with these computers ›](#)
- [macOS Sequoia 15 is compatible with these computers ›](#)
- [macOS Sonoma 14 is compatible with these computers ›](#)
- [macOS Ventura 13 is compatible with these computers ›](#)
- [macOS Monterey 12 is compatible with these computers ›](#)
- [macOS Big Sur 11 is compatible with these computers ›](#)
- [macOS Catalina 10.15 is compatible with these computers ›](#)

Learn more

- [Learn about Apple software updates](#), including why it’s important to update your software, how software updates work, and their performance and battery impact.
- [If an error occurs while updating or installing macOS](#)
- [If your Mac doesn't start up all the way](#).

Need more help?

Tell us more about what's happening, and we’ll suggest what you can do next.

[Get suggestions ›](#)

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Helpful?

Yes

No